The sharp basil and lime cream melting into this soup is a perfect finish for special occasions. For a more everyday dinner, however, you can leave it out.

winter squash soup with basil and lime cream

SERVES 6–8 **PREP** 25 MINS **COOK** 35 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS AT THE END OF STEP 2

5 garlic cloves
1 large onion, chopped
1in (2.5cm) piece ginger, peeled and coarsely chopped
3 tbsp oil
3lb 3oz (1.5 kg) winter squash, such as pumpkin, butternut, or acorn, seeds and rind removed, coarsely cubed
2 sprigs of parsley
1 sprig of thyme
1 bay leaf
3 star anise
12oz (350g) tomatoes, peeled, seeded, and coarsely chopped
2 quarts (2 liters) hot vegetable stock or chicken stock
salt and freshly ground black pepper
1¼ cups heavy whipping cream
juice of 1–2 limes
small handful of basil leaves, chopped, to serve

1 Chop two of the garlic cloves, but leave the rest whole. Put the chopped garlic and the whole garlic into a large pan with the onion, ginger, oil, and squash. Tie the herbs together in a bundle and toss those in too. Cover with a lid and cook over low heat for 10 minutes, stirring once or twice.

2 Add the star anise, tomatoes, and stock, then season with salt and freshly ground black pepper and bring to a boil. Simmer for 20 minutes or until the squash is tender. Pick out and discard the bundle of herbs and the star anise. Process the soup in a blender until smooth and then pass it through a sieve. Taste and adjust the seasoning, then reheat gently.

3 Meanwhile, pour the cream into a bowl, add the lime juice, and whisk. Once the cream holds its shape loosely, stir in the basil. As you ladle the soup into bowls, top with a floating crown of basil and lime cream.